The Physician

By John Patrick

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

NOTE: Actor 2 plays the roles of the NURSE and the PATIENT; Actor 1 Plays the role of the DOCTOR.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Do you have complete confidence in your doctor?*
ACTOR 2: *Me? I don't believe in doctors and more than I believe in Santa Claus!*
ACTOR 1: *Really? Doctors are the backbone of our medical system. What if you got really, really sick?*
ACTOR 2: *Nope . . . when it's my time to go, it's my time to go. Ever since I went to Doctor Craven that one time for a simple sore throat . . . I've vowed that I would never go back to a doctor again! Let me tell you about it . . . no, wait – I'll show you exactly what happened!*
TOGETHER: *The Physician by John Patrick.*

AT RISE: Doctor Craven, an attractive, but very jittery physician in his thirties, is discovered meditating on the floor in front of his desk squatting in the traditional "lotus" position. His affable nurse enters.

DOCTOR: *(Without opening his eyes.)* Ssshl *(His nurse sighs and stands waiting patiently. After a moment she speaks.)*

NURSE: Doctor -

DOCTOR: Sssshl *(His Nurse leans back against the door to wait. The Doctor begins to hum a chant, sounding somewhat like a Hindu Cantor. Then with a satisfied smile, he opens his eyes, and takes a deep breath.)* Wait! Damn! *(He struggles to get his legs unfolded.)*

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NURSE: What's the matter? Can't you get out of your lotus position?

DOCTOR: *(Alarmed.)* Nol It's my cranial nerves. I think I'm paralyzed.

NURSE: Oh, come on now, Doctor. You're just stuck. *(Crosses to him.)*

DOCTOR: Don't argue with me. Can't you see I've just suffered a motor impairment. I knew something was wrong with me this morning when I threw up my yogurt.

NURSE: You haven't had a stroke. You've just got a cramp. Here, let me help unwind you. *(She kneels and pulls his legs apart)* There. *(Rises and offers her hand to get him to his feet).*

DOCTOR: No. Don't get close to me. You've got a cold.

NURSE: I have not got a cold!

DOCTOR: I heard you sneezing out there, twice. Doctors are exposed to every disease known to man and beast . . . And some pigeons. If I were an insurance company, I wouldn't insure a doctor for ten cents. *(Stops.)* Incidentally, is my policy paid up?

NURSE: Would you like to increase it? There was a pigeon on the window sill yesterday.

DOCTOR: Wait'll I have a few more symptoms. I'm a doctor and I know I'm a very sick doctor.

NURSE: What do you think is the matter with you?

DOCTOR: I don't know. People are dying every day from diseases we haven't discovered yet.

NURSE: Maybe you should see a doctor, Doctor.

DOCTOR: I might have caught something they've never heard of.

NURSE: Doctor, this is becoming an obsession. I don't know what is happening to you. I think you ought to see a psychiatrist. They cure people of all sorts of things.

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DOCTOR: Well, I never heard of analysis curing a hemorrhoid.

NURSE: I think your trouble is a little higher up, Doctor. Frankly, in my opinion, you're becoming a paranoid hypochondriac.

DOCTOR: Me? A hypochondriac? You're fired!

NURSE: After fifteen years?

DOCTOR: I can't afford the tension you cause me in my present physical condition. Write yourself two weeks severance pay.

NURSE: Oh, this is preposterous! Shall I send in your first patient now. He's been waiting an hour.

DOCTOR: Let him wait. That'll teach him to get sick. Taking up my time. I'll buzz you after I've taken my temperature. And a few pills. *(She goes out.)*

DOCTOR: *(To self.)* Hypochondriac, indeed! *(He goes to a wall mirror and sticks out his tongue to examine. Next he pulls his eyelid down. He then goes to a basin and washes his hands. Having done this, he gargles three times, each on a progressively higher musical note. He concludes his self-examination by spraying his throat. To self.)* Hypochondriac! Women - what do they know. *(He then takes an aerosol can and sprays the room, even spraying under a book. He sits down at his and puts a thermometer in his mouth.)*

NURSE: *(sticking her head in the doorway)* Are you ready for your first patient now?

DOCTOR: *(With the thermometer in his mouth, his words are almost indistinguishable.)* No, but I might as well start. (*Removes thermometer.)* Send him in. *(Returns thermometer to his mouth as she exits, then takes it out to read. To self.)* Normal? Damned unreliable thermometer. Probably made in Mexico. *(He opens a bottle of pills and begins popping them into his mouth, one after the other - a dozen at least. His nurse returns and stands aside.)*

NURSE: The doctor will see you now. *(A pleasant-looking man enters expectantly and*

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takes off his hat.)

DOCTOR: Come in. Sit down, sir. *(His patient starts to shift the chair closer to the desk.)* Don't move it closer!

PATIENT: Why not?

DOCTOR: Germs. Germs are air-borne and we're air-conditioned. Now, what seems to be wrong with you?

PATIENT: That's what I want *you* to tell me. Actually, Doctor, all I really have is a slightly inflamed throat. I just dropped in to get a prescription.

DOCTOR: How do you know it's just a sore throat? Optimism has caused more deaths than the tsetse fly.

PATIENT: Well, I haven't exactly been bothered this winter by flies.

DOCTOR: We'd better have a look. God knows what we'll find. *(He first sprays the area around the Patient with his aerosol.)*

PATIENT: What's that - a tsetse fly spray?

DOCTOR: This whole world is divided into two hostile armies - people and germs.

PATIENT: Who's winning?

DOCTOR: You and I - so far. Now, it's safe to open your mouth and stick out your tongue.

PATIENT: How far?

DOCTOR: Whole hog. *(The Patient sticks out his tongue.)* My God - your tongue is blue! Sit down quickly. You're riddled with Blue Fungus.

PATIENT: Not to worry, Doctor. I had blueberry muffins for breakfast.

DOCTOR: *Don't do that to me!* I'm not well. Now, I have to take a tranquilizer because of you. *(He gets a pill and swallows it.)*

DOCTOR: Well, let's look at your tongue again. *(Patient slides out tongue.)* Hmmmm. Remarkable. . . . The only time I've ever seen a tongue as

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long as yours was on an iguana.

PATIENT: But am I going to live?

DOCTOR: Your tongue does seem a little swollen.

PATIENT: What could cause that?

DOCTOR: I thought you'd never ask. It could be a fungus of the mucus membrane or infectious mononeucleosis. On the other hand, I don't rule out congenital hypothyroidism.

PATIENT: Is that good or bad?

DOCTOR: Not bad. Of course, that *can* cause dwarfism, sparse hair, yellow skin, distended abdomen, puffy face, thick lips, depressed nose, tooth eruption, swollen tongue and constipation. Otherwise, it doesn't impair your normal activities.

PATIENT: As what? A dwarf?

DOCTOR: Well, let's take the bull by the horns and look at your throat.

PATIENT: Doctor, it's only a *little* soreness.

DOCTOR: Little? Just a little naked germ you can't see with the naked eye. And what can a little, little germ do? Nothing! *Except* cause plague, decimate a democracy, pollute a people, terminate a tribe, eradicate a race and cause a global fungus where no potatoes or peanuts could germinate for generations. Now, stick your tongue out and say "ah."

PATIENT: Ahh - *(It sounds more like a sob of anguish.)*

DOCTOR: So my diagnosis is simply this –

PATIENT: I'm going to die?

DOCTOR: No. You have nothing more than a mild sore throat. Are you relieved?

PATIENT: Yes - but I wish you hadn't used a cannon to shoot a rabbit.

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DOCTOR: Just gargle a little salt in hot water. *(Picks up pencil)* Now. My brilliant nurse failed to give me your name. I assume you have one?

PATIENT: Charles Abbott. Doctor Charles Abbott.

DOCTOR: Doctor?

PATIENT: That's right.

DOCTOR: *(Leaps to his feet)* A doctor! Oh, my God - God loves me. *(He races to the Patient)* Heaven has sent you to me! I need a doctor to confirm the fact that I'm a very sick. Sit down. Draw your chair up closer. Look at my tongue. *(He sticks it out.)*

PATIENT: But I'm not qualified to make a diagnosis for you. I'm a veterinarian. I could only treat you if you were a dog.

DOCTOR: Where's your humanity. Am I less than a Doberman? All I want is an opinion. You know when a dog is sick by its tongue. Why not me? Look. *(Sticks out his tongue again.)*

PATIENT: *(Studies his tongue.)* Well, if you were a dog, I'd say you had rabies.

DOCTOR: I knew I'd caught something. Feel my pulse. I promise you - it'll be a new experience for you. *(Extends wrist)*

PATIENT: *(Holds wrist.)* Seems normal to me.

DOCTOR: Normal for what? Me or a Doberman?

PATIENT: Doctor, surely you must realize there is a great difference in the bodily functions between you and a Doberman.

DOCTOR: Name *one.* We all have similar organs.

PATIENT: Do you lift your leg to micturate?

DOCTOR: It's the same function.

PATIENT: Try it in public.

DOCTOR: Well, I'm *sick.* as a dog. All I want is corroboration. Treat me like a dog.

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PATIENT: Have you swallowed any foreign objects lately?

DOCTOR: Just seaweed.

PATIENT: No coins? Or keys?

DOCTOR: No. But I'm about to swallow my pride. Doctor, I'm on my knees. I know I've caught something from a patient. You wouldn't understand that because you're a veterinarian and they don't catch things from their patients.

PATIENT: Oh, but they do.

DOCTOR: What possible diseases can a veterinarian catch from a sick cat?

PATIENT: Not diseases. Fleas.

DOCTOR: Fleas are not fatal. Fertile but not fatal. *(Hands him a stethoscope.)* Here - listen to my heart and tell me how bad it is.

PATIENT: *(Uses stethoscope.)* I'd say you're strong as a horse. Or at least an ox.

DOCTOR: Then the trouble must be someplace else. The human body is a jigsaw puzzle. We have to find the right part. *(He drops his pants.)*

PATIENT: Doctor - I've just met you!

DOCTOR: Maybe I've got a hernia. Or terminal hemorroids. Feel my hiatus.

PATIENT: Doctor, I really don't think I know you well enough.

DOCTOR: Maybe you'd better look into my prostrate.

PATIENT: Doctor Craven, I wouldn't look at your prostate unless I could see it through your throat. *(Starts to get his hat. The Doctor hobbles after him, impeded by the trousers around his ankles.) (He goes out.)*

DOCTOR: Some doctor! I wouldn't send him a constipated canary. *(Goes to mirror and looks at tongue. His nurse enters.)*

NURSE: What was that patient laughing about as he left?

DOCTOR: He has a perverted sense of humor. I guess he thought my prostate was funny.

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NURSE: He was a doctor?

DOCTOR: Not in my books.

NURSE: What are you doing with your shirt off?

DOCTOR: I was going to wash it - what else. Here. *(He hands her his stethoscope.)* See if my heartbeat is normal.

NURSE: What side is your heart on?

DOCTOR: The right side.

NURSE: *(Listens to his chest.)* It's there alright. I can hear a thump. *(Stares at Doctor's chest.)* Oh, good Lord! I can't believe it!

DOCTOR: What is it? Am I hemorrhaging?

NURSE: No. But you've caught something from that doctor who just left. *(Races to get aerosol can.)*

DOCTOR: What is it? A sore throat? *(Sticks out his tongue like a lizard after a fly·)*

NURSE: *(Grabs a can.)* I think I'm just in time. *(Races back.)* Don't move. Stand perfectly still.

DOCTOR: For God's sake - what is it? What have I caught?

NURSE: Fleas! *(As she sprays his chest the curtain descends.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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